Another archaeological haul yielded a cache of twenty-one small soapstone discs. They were found packed together in a dried-up watercourse in the Murtaziganj locality.[36] Pieces of exquisite workmanship, with a great variety of fine detail, these miniature discs depict lotus flowers, nude female figures that are thought to be goddesses of fertility, and a profusion of birds and animals arranged in circles—parrots, peacocks, and geese; lions, stags, elephants, and horses; even an owl and a rhinoceros.[37] Why the discs were made and the purpose for which they were used are not clear, but they are carved with such exceptional skill that the supposition is they were meant to catch the eye of an elite clientele that probably used them in some sort of ritual. But the localities where such elites lived within the city have, like the royal palaces, not survived.

Having sufficiently rued the vanished structures of the Mauryan empire, let us look instead at an inestimable treasure that miraculously survived and has been found, namely the *Arthashastra* by Kautilya.[38] This is a text extensively used by practically everyone who writes on the Mauryas. Like the ramparts of Pataliputra, it remained hidden from scholarly gaze for many centuries: despite numerous allusions to it in later literature, as a material artefact the text was not in evidence.[39] The first manuscript appeared in 1904 when a pandit of Tanjore district handed over a set of 168 palm leaf folios in the Grantha script, along with the fragment of a Sanskrit commentary, to R. Shamasastry, librarian of the Mysore Governmental Oriental Library. Shamasastry soon realized that what he had acquired was the first available manuscript of the *Arthashastra*. This he went on to edit and publish, first in successive volumes of *Indian Antiquary* and eventually as a book.[40] While the manuscript was no more than a century or two old, Shamasastry recognized it as a copy of a much older text on ancient statecraft, one which could be dated to the time of the Mauryas. Several other manuscripts were later unearthed, some complete, others with a few folios missing, mainly in libraries in Travancore, Madras, and Cochin, with